Get started

Quickstart

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Use Ollama in **desktop apps** and **coding agents**, or **build an application** with an API key.

Get started

Download Ollama for macOS, Windows, or Linux. Open the app, or get started from your terminal:

```
ollama
```

Follow the setup prompts. Sign in to use cloud models, or choose a local model.

Connect a desktop app

On macOS, open Ollama and select **Apps**. Connect **Claude** or **ChatGPT (Desktop)**. Follow the prompts to install or restart the app.

Choose your Ollama models in **Settings → Apps**.

- **Claude Desktop** — use Ollama models in Claude.
- **ChatGPT Desktop** — use Ollama models in Codex mode. Regular Chat and voice use your usual ChatGPT connection.

Use a coding agent

From your project directory, launch your agent:

Claude Code | Codex CLI | OpenCode

```
ollama launch claude
```

Ollama offers to install Claude Code if needed. See **Claude Code** for details.

Choose a model when prompted, then try:

```
Explain how this repository is organized.
```

For more tools, see **Integrations**. To connect an agent directly with an API key, see **Claude Code**.

Build an application

Use cloud models with an API key, or run models locally without one. Cloud requests do not require an Ollama installation.

1. Create an API key

For local models, skip this step and select **Local** under **Send a request**.

For cloud models, sign in or create an account, then create an **API key**.

Set your key in the terminal:

macOS / Linux | Windows

```
export OLLAMA_API_KEY="your_api_key"
```



Keep your key on your application's server, outside browser code and source control.

2. Send a request

Make your first request to Ollama

Cloud Local

These examples use the `gemma4:31b` **cloud model**.

Ollama API OpenAI Chat Completions OpenAI Responses Anthropic Messages

```
curl https://ollama.com/api/chat \
  -H "Authorization: Bearer $OLLAMA_API_KEY" \
  -H "Content-Type: application/json" \
  -d '{
    "model": "gemma4:31b",
    "messages": [
      {
        "role": "user",
        "content": "Say hello in one sentence."
      }
    ],
    "stream": false
  }'
```

Read the answer from `message.content` . See **Ollama's API and libraries**.

OpenAI and Anthropic compatibility each cover a subset of the original API. See **Cloud** for models and usage limits.

Run a model locally

Download Ollama, then run:



```
ollama run gemma4:e2b
```

Ollama downloads the model and starts a chat on your computer. Type `/bye` to leave.

Next steps

Add **tool calling**, **stream responses**, or browse **more models**.

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